

MOHAMMED SIRAJ 31

Right-arm fast bowler

Test
Matches: 41
Wickets: 123
Avg: 31.05
Best bowling 6/15

The destiny's child of the India–England Test series, Siraj was the protagonist of some of its key moments—the brazen brush against Ben Duckett after dismissing him at Lord's; his crestfallen state after the ball rolled back to dislodge the bails on day five of the same game, giving England a 2–1 lead; the botched catch of Harry Brook on the boundary on day four of the fifth Test that nearly handed England the match. It seemed fate was playing a cruel game with the 31-year-old Hyderabadi. But 'BELIEVE' is not just a screenshot on his phone,it's part of his DNA. Siraj never stopped believing in himself. With Bumrah sitting out two Tests, Siraj had to lead India's pace attack. He stepped up—1,122 balls to be precise—and has 23 wickets to show for it. "You play for the country...you don't think too much on how many overs [you] bowled," he said after the final Test at The Oval was won, and he was named Player of the Match for his nine wickets. It is befitting then that Siraj had his moment of glory. In him, a nation now believes.

—Suhani Singh

tans, continued. The dual responsibility seemed to have galvanised him. More than the numbers, it was Gill's temperament that made an impression. Usually seen as gentle and self-contained, this series brought out a rawer version of him. His verbal volleys at the English batters for their time-wasting tactics at Lord's—delivered with a fire reminiscent of Virat Kohli—signalled a young man growing into the job. Questions arose: would going against his natural temperament affect his batting rhythm? The answer came soon enough: a gritty century at Manchester in the very next Test, and a Player of the Series award at the end of the tour, put those doubts to rest.

But leadership isn't just about runs and rants, it's about trust. And Gill earned it in spades. Many in the squad had more Test experience. Some were contenders for the captaincy themselves before being overtaken by the boy from the frontier town of Fazilka, southwest Punjab. Yet, they synchronised perfectly to the conductor's tune, aligning their personal targets to the team's goal, ready to give their all when the occasion demanded. This was the biggest approbation of Gill the captain.

Never give up was the ethos of the Indian team that stared down adversity, the weight of expectations, and never blinked

Opener K.L. Rahul's insights on the dressing room air jive perfectly with what the world observed from the sidelines: "Shubman has been phenomenal. He has led from the front, really worked hard with the boys behind the scenes as well as in forming connections...which a lot of people don't see. He'll take this Indian team to great heights." Gill's captaincy will still need refining— tactically, he's a work in progress. But while a captain can be appointed, a leader must rise. And rise he did, in the summer of 2025.